Physical Appearance and Elections: An Inequality Perspective

Hector Bahamonde [1] Outi Sarpila [1]

[1]University of Turku, Finland

April 7th, 2022

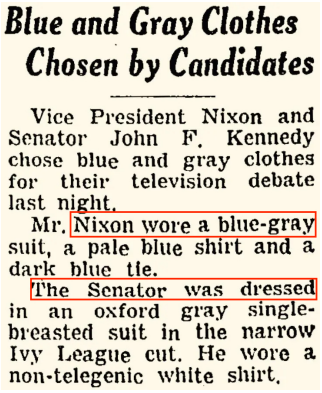
TV, Looks and Political Branding

- During the 1950s and the 1960s, the TV gets massively introduced in American homes.
- This opened up new possibilities for **political campaigning**.



TV, Looks and Political Branding

- The **first televised presidential debate** was in 1960: Nixon vs. Kennedy.
- For the first time, make up, posture, clothing (**physical appearance!**) began to matter.



Blue and Gray Clothes Chosen by Candidates

Vice President Nixon and Senator John F. Kennedy chose blue and gray clothes for their television debate last night.

Mr. Nixon wore a blue-gray suit, a pale blue shirt and a dark blue tie.

The Senator was dressed in an oxford gray single-breasted suit in the narrow Ivy League cut. He wore a non-telegenic white shirt.

The Times (London 1960).

Nixon-Kennedy 1960 Debate

- Nixon's "five-o'clock shadow" negatively affected his evaluation.

  Mattes et. al (2010).

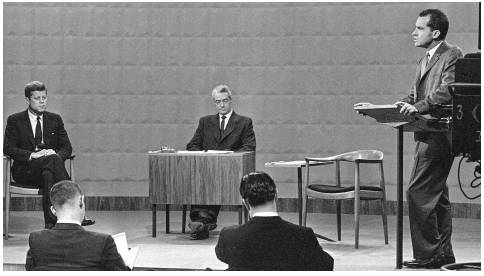


Nixon-Kennedy 1960 Debate

- Nixon's "five-o'clock shadow" negatively affected his evaluation.

  Mattes et. al (2010).

- Nixon's posture didn't look "presidential."



Nixon-Kennedy 1960 Debate

- Nixon's "five-o'clock shadow" negatively affected his evaluation.

  Mattes et. al (2010).

- Nixon's posture didn't look "presidential."
- Nixon was all sweaty.

  Stockemer and Praino (2019).



Nixon-Kennedy 1960 Debate



Radio listeners thought Nixon would win, while TV-watchers though Kennedy would.

Good-looking Candidates do Better in Elections

- We know that better-looking candidates are more likely to win elections.
- "**Voters vote beautiful**" (Efrain and Patterson, 1974) because "**beautiful is good**" (Dion et al., 1972).



"What Are Good-Looking Candidates?" (Stockemer and Praino, 2019)

What About Wealthy-looking or Poor-looking Candidates?

- While we know that better-looking candidates win more often, we're rather ignorant about the effects of *looking* poor/wealthy on the probability of winning elections.
- This questions is relevant because it touches upon issues of social stratification and voting choices.

Inequality Perspective: Social Stratification and Elections

- **Identify** that the literature *only* looks at candidate attractiveness, which is just *one* dimension of physical appearance.
- **Beyond attractiveness** and explore the degree in which a candidate's **social class** affects the number of votes received.
- **Empirics**: we exploit a novel data set of candidate physical appearances (2017 Finnish Municipal Elections).
- **(*Uncomfortable*) results**

Inequality Perspective: Social Stratification and Elections

- **Identify** that the literature *only* looks at candidate attractiveness, which is just *one* dimension of physical appearance.
- **Beyond attractiveness** and explore the degree in which a candidate's **social class** affects the number of votes received.
- **Empirics**: we exploit a novel data set of candidate physical appearances (2017 Finnish Municipal Elections).
- **(*Uncomfortable*) results**: Finns systematically...
  1. Punish **working-class-*looking*** candidates, and

Inequality Perspective: Social Stratification and Elections

- **Identify** that the literature *only* looks at candidate attractiveness, which is just *one* dimension of physical appearance.
- **Beyond attractiveness** and explore the degree in which a candidate's **social class** affects the number of votes received.
- **Empirics**: we exploit a novel data set of candidate physical appearances (2017 Finnish Municipal Elections).
- **(*Uncomfortable*) results**: Finns systematically...
  1. Punish **working-class-*looking*** candidates, and
  2. the fx's are stronger in **female** candidates.

Political Psychology: Heuristics

- A candidate's **physical appearance** is "the most important" (Lau & Redlawsk 2001) and the "most obvious and accessible" (Dion et al. 1972) *heuristic* available to voters (Stockemer & Praino 2017).

Political Psychology: Heuristics

- A candidate's **physical appearance** is "the most important" (Lau & Redlawsk 2001) and the "most obvious and accessible" (Dion et al. 1972) *heuristic* available to voters (Stockemer & Praino 2017).
- **Heuristics** are cognitive devices that allow **reasonable voting decision making with minimal effort** (Lau & Redlawsk 2001 and Tversky & Kahneman 1973).

Political Psychology: Heuristics

- A candidate's **physical appearance** is "the most important" (Lau & Redlawsk 2001) and the "most obvious and accessible" (Dion et al. 1972) *heuristic* available to voters (Stockemer & Praino 2017).
- **Heuristics** are cognitive devices that allow **reasonable voting decision making with minimal effort** (Lau & Redlawsk 2001 and Tversky & Kahneman 1973).
- Thus, "voters vote beautiful" (Efrain & Patterson 1974) because attractive candidates "are more likely to be attributed the qualities associated with successful politicians" (Stockemer & Praino 2019).

Status Expectations Theory

- **Status Expectations Theory**: physical attractiveness is considered a similar status characteristic as gender or occupation.
  - ✓ For ex., attractive people are 'better' or 'more capable' (Webster & Driskell 1983).

Status Expectations Theory

- **Status Expectations Theory**: physical attractiveness is considered a similar status characteristic as gender or occupation.
  - ✓ For ex., attractive people are 'better' or 'more capable' (Webster & Driskell 1983).
- We extend this concept to cues of **occupation** as a **status** characteristic.

We **argue** that the information about a candidate's occupation combined with his/her physical appearance function as cue of status, in turn affecting his/her likelihood of winning an election.

We **argue** that the information about a candidate's occupation combined with his/her physical appearance function as cue of status, in turn affecting his/her likelihood of winning an election.

- **Expectations**:
  - Since voters use **heuristics**, they will systematically elect '**high-status looking**' candidates.
    - ✓ Upper-class looking candidates.
    - ✓ Male candidates.
  - **Lower status** candidates will signal lower performance expectations, thus, receiving **less votes**.

Finland as a Hard Case

- We follow a "**least-likely case design**" (Levy 2008). Finland has been consistently considered as:
  - A democratic (Polity-V).
  - An economic egalitarian (Waltl 2022).
  - A gender egalitarian.
  - A social-mobility prone country (Erola 2009).
- Thus, it should be **hard to find** a correlation between class-congruent use of status symbols and voting.

...and yet, we *do*.

Municipal Elections in Finland

- **Municipal Elections**: held every four years to elect councilors of the different municipalities (N=293).
- **D'Hondt**: candidates run in party lists. Seats are filled with lists of candidates proportionally.
- **Municipalities**: provide daycare, health, education, water, waste management, among others.

Campaigns: Plain, Simple and Fair

- **Public posters**: shown in city centers, bus stops, *and* voting booths!
- Municipalities *must* provide the *same* number of poster slots for all parties.
- **"Low-information" elections**: most voters get exposed to only the official candidate pictures shown in the posters.

(Berggren et al. 2010 & 2017).



Average Poster Displaying Candidates Faces in Finnish Elections

2017 Municipal Elections: Candidate Data

- **Ministry of Justice**: candidate's pictures, district, occupation and voting data.
- **Sample**: Universe 33,618, possible 10,000, randomly selected **1,500 candidate photographs**.
- **Occupation**: European Socio-economic Classification, recoded each candidate's occupation (upper, middle and working class).

Novel Raters Data

- Collected data from 7,920 randomly selected Finnish-speaking Finns.
- **Task**: evaluated a random sample of candidate photographs according to four items (N∼50).
- **Items**:
  1. **Occupation-Appearance congruence.** *Does this person look like the profession he/she is declaring?*
  2. **Attractiveness.**
  3. **Masculinity.**
  4. **Femininity.**
- **Avoiding recognition**: proprietary software designed to avoid assigning candidates running in the same rater's district.

▸ show table with items ▸ show distributions

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
&\beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
&\beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
&\gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
&\gamma 2 \text{City}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

- **Also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- **Partition the data** (full, male & female).

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
\beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
\beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
\gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
\gamma 2 \text{City}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

- **Also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- **Partition the data** (full, male & female).

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
\beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
\beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
\gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
\gamma 2 \text{City}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

- **Also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- **Partition the data** (full, male & female).

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
&\beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
&\beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
&\gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
&\gamma 2 \text{City}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

- **Also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- **Partition the data** (full, male & female).

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
\beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
\beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
\gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
\gamma 2 \text{City}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

- **Also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- **Partition the data** (full, male & female).

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
&\beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
&\beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
&\gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
&\gamma 2 \text{City}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

- **Also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- **Partition the data** (full, male & female).

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
&\beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
&\beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
&\gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
&\gamma 2 \text{City}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

- **Also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- **Partition the data** (full, male & female).

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
&\beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
&\beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
&\gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
&\gamma 2 \text{City}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

- **Also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- **Partition the data** (full, male & female).

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
\beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
\beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
\gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
\gamma 2 \text{City}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

- **Also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- **Partition the data** (full, male & female).

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
\beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
\beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
\gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
\gamma 2 \text{City}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

- **Also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- **Partition the data** (full, male & female).

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
&\beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
&\beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
&\gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
&\gamma 2 \text{City}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

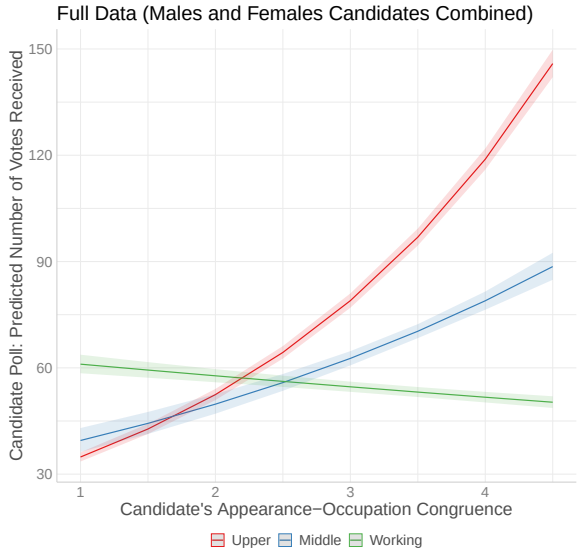
- **Also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- **Partition the data** (full, male & female).

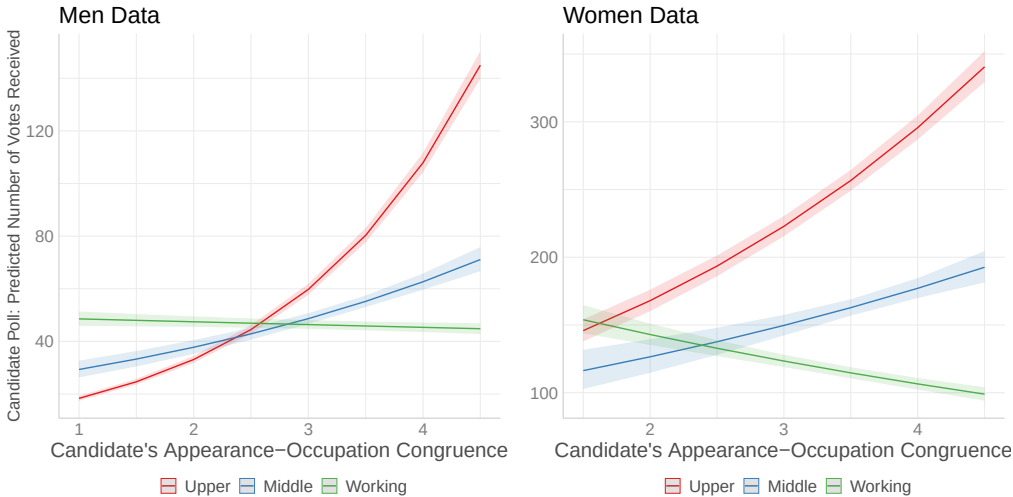
Table: Statistical Models

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
	Full	Male	Female	Full	Full	Full	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female
Intercept	4.49***	2.58***	6.17***	2.11***	4.27***	2.15***	−0.25**	3.24***	2.50***	2.98***	0.17	2.80***
	(0.05)	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.08)
Appearance-Occupation Congruence	0.41***	0.59***	0.28***	0.25***	0.42***	0.26***	0.37***	0.22***	0.59***	0.28***	0.37***	0.24***
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Middle Class	0.30***	0.81***	−0.05	0.41***	0.23***	0.31***	0.54***	0.12	0.77***	0.18	0.75***	0.16
	(0.06)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.08)	(0.11)
Working Class	1.03***	1.59***	0.70***	0.49***	1.07***	0.58***	0.95***	0.23***	1.59***	0.32***	0.86***	0.19**
	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.04)	(0.07)
Age	−0.02***	−0.01***	−0.03***	−0.00***	−0.02***	−0.01***	0.00***	−0.01***	−0.01***	−0.02***	0.01***	−0.01***
	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)
Appearance-Occupation Congruence × Middle Class	−0.18***	−0.34***	−0.11***	−0.20***	−0.16***	−0.17***	−0.22***	−0.17***	−0.33***	−0.19***	−0.28***	−0.18***
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.03)
Appearance-Occupation Congruence × Working Class	−0.46***	−0.61***	−0.43***	−0.28***	−0.48***	−0.31***	−0.39***	−0.28***	−0.62***	−0.29***	−0.35***	−0.27***
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.02)
Attractiveness				0.76***		0.89***	1.00***	0.72***			1.08***	0.53***
				(0.01)		(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)			(0.01)	(0.01)
Masculinity					0.09***				0.04***		−0.28***	
					(0.00)				(0.01)		(0.01)	
Femininity						−0.15***				0.68***		0.26***
						(0.00)				(0.01)		(0.02)
AIC	287653.94	170596.79	79111.45	267973.43	287029.77	265328.79	154959.12	73290.19	170577.24	74331.79	153861.01	73001.39
BIC	288886.12	171561.82	79936.45	269210.66	288267.17	266571.24	155928.83	74119.20	171546.96	75161.13	154835.41	73834.74
Log Likelihood	−143590.97	−85092.40	−39365.73	−133749.72	−143277.88	−132426.40	−77272.56	−36454.09	−85081.62	−36974.89	−76722.51	−36308.70
Deviance	278666.41	165250.11	75150.60	258990.24	278040.23	256343.60	149610.43	69333.68	165228.56	70368.94	148510.33	69042.88
Num. obs.	1368	800	568	1367	1368	1367	800	567	800	568	800	567

$^{***}p < 0.001$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{*}p < 0.05$.

Dependent variable is the number of votes each candidate received. City fixed effects and party variables omitted. The reference category in the ESEC variable is 'Upper Class.' Given the symmetry of the derivatives, changing the reference category does not alter the interpretation of the results. Functional form is Poisson regression for all models.


Full Data (Males and Females Candidates Combined)
Candidate Poll: Predicted Number of Votes Received
150
120
90
60
30
1
2
3
4
Candidate's Appearance−Occupation Congruence
Upper
Middle
Working


Men Data
Candidate Poll: Predicted Number of Votes Received
120
80
40
1
2
3
4
Candidate's Appearance−Occupation Congruence
Upper
Middle
Working
Women Data
300
200
100
2
3
4
Candidate's Appearance−Occupation Congruence
Upper
Middle
Working

Candidate's Gender	Status	Pred.Votes	95% CI	
Female	Don't look like working class	154	144	165
	Look a lot like working class	99	94	104
Male	Don't look like working class	49	46	51
	Look a lot like working class	45	43	47

Candidate's Gender	Status	Pred.Votes	95% CI	
Female	Don't look like working class	154	144	165
	Look a lot like working class	99	94	104
Male	Don't look like working class	49	46	51
	Look a lot like working class	45	43	47

Candidate's Gender	Status	Pred.Votes	95% CI	
Female	Don't look like working class	154	144	165
	Look a lot like working class	99	94	104
Male	Don't look like working class	49	46	51
	Look a lot like working class	45	43	47

Candidate's Gender	Status	Pred.Votes	95% CI	
Female	Don't look like working class	154	144	165
	Look a lot like working class	99	94	104
Male	Don't look like working class	49	46	51
	Look a lot like working class	45	43	47

Candidate's Gender	Status	Pred.Votes	95% CI	
Female	Don't look like working class	154	144	165
	Look a lot like working class	99	94	104
Male	Don't look like working class	49	46	51
	Look a lot like working class	45	43	47

Main Results

- **Male & female** candidates:
  - ✓ Candidates that look-like and also perform *upper-class occupations* do **best** in elections.

Main Results

- **Male & female** candidates:
  - ✓ Candidates that look-like and also perform *upper-class occupations* do **best** in elections.
- **Female** candidates:
  - Systematic electoral penalty when they **look-like** and also **perform working-class occupations**.
  - This is represents a 36%*** marginal change.

Main Results

- **Male & female** candidates:
  - ✓ Candidates that look-like and also perform *upper-class occupations* do **best** in elections.
- **Female** candidates:
  - Systematic electoral penalty when they **look-like** and also **perform working-class occupations**.
  - This is represents a 36%*** marginal change.
- **Male** candidates:
  - *Don't* experience the same electoral punishment: it does *not* matter (electorally) if a male candidate looks working-class.

Main Takeaways

- ✓ Considered **the use of heuristics in elections** and the concept of **"status" in expectation states theory**.
- ✓ Selected the ***unlikely* case** of the 2017 Finnish Municipal Elections.
- ✓ Exploited a **novel representative data set** of candidates' physical appearances.
- ✓ Proposed an alternative explanation for **voting** not based on attractiveness but on **occupation-appearance congruence** and **social stratification**.
- ✓ Female candidates experience a systematic **electoral penalty** when they **look working-class**.

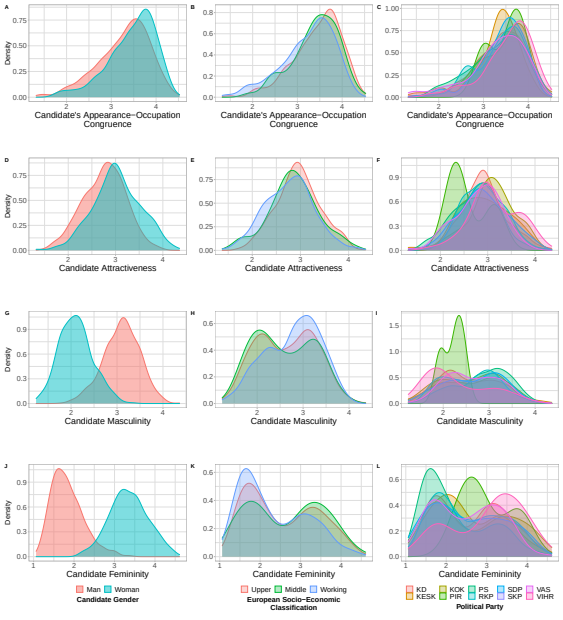
Thank you



to check out updates on this project.

Raters Data: Questions and Answer Set

Sample	Attribute	Question	Answer Set
1	Occupation-Appearance Congruence	To what extent does this person respond to your image of someone working in [occupation]?	5=Perfectly responds to my image, 4=Responds well to my image, 3=Somewhat responds to my image, 2=Does not respond to my image well, 1=Does not respond to my image at all.
2	Attractiveness	In your opinion, how attractive does this person look, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	5=very attractive, 4=more attractive than the average, 3=average, 2=below average, 1=well below average (Griffin and Langois 2006; Bono et al. 2017; Tu, Gilbert and Bono 2021)
3	Masculinity	To what extent do you think this person looks masculine, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	1=not masculine at all, to 5=very masculine (e.g., Hoss et al. 2005).
4	Femininity	To what extent do you think this person looks feminine, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	1=not feminine at all, to 5=very feminine.


Raters Data: Distributions of Candidate Phys. App.
A
B
C
D
E
F
G
H
I
J
K
L
Density
Candidate's Appearance−Occupation Congruence
Candidate Attractiveness
Candidate Masculinity
Candidate Femininity
Man
Woman
Candidate Gender
Upper
Middle
Working
European Socio−Economic Classification
KD
KESK
KOK
PIR
PS
RKP
SDP
SKP
VAS
VIHR
Political Party